Indoor Air Quality

Policy Subcommittee Meeting



PORTLAND
Public Schools

11.16.26

Recommendation on Proposed Indoor Air Quality (IAQ) Policy Additions

- **Core Recommendation:** Pause adoption of IAQ additions to the Climate Crisis Response Policy (CCRP).

- **Policy Separation:** If desired, establish Indoor Air Quality (IAQ) as a standalone policy with dedicated leadership (IAQ Coordinator).

- **Primary Objective:** Protect the current scope of the CCRP goals while defining a separate and rigorous indoor environmental health policy, if needed.



Core Policy Misalignment:
Why IAQ & CCRP Should Remain Separate

- **Scope & Focus Shift:**
  - **CCRP Focus:** Global emissions mitigation, decarbonization, and long-term climate action (net-zero by 2040).
  - **IAQ Focus:** Micro-environmental public health and occupational safety protocols, which historically exist as internal Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs).
- **Risk of Policy Dilution:**
  - Combining daily occupational health mandates and global decarbonization in one policy dilutes core CCRP objectives.
  - Pivots Climate Justice, Energy & Sustainability (CJES) team priority from structural carbon reduction to routine maintenance.
- **Governance Alignment:**
  - Operational metrics evolve rapidly; standard operating procedures (SOPs) and Environmental Health & Safety (EH&S) frameworks provide proper flexibility compared to rigid policy language.



Energy & Emissions Impact
Conflict Between IAQ & CCRP

- **Ventilation vs. Carbon Goals:**
  - Targeting 6 to 12 Air Changes per Hour (ACH) requires continuous HVAC operation and high intake of unconditioned outdoor air.
- **Increased Energy Consumption:**
  - HVAC energy usage would increase by **10% to 40% per site**.
  - Directly conflicts with CCRP mandate to prioritize investments achieving the *greatest emissions reduction*.
- **Impact on CCRP Targets:**
  - Higher energy demand creates significant headwinds against reaching district-wide net-zero targets.



Financial & Resource Constraints

- **Estimated Annual Operating Cost Increase (per site):**
  - **Elementary School (e.g., Atkinson):** +$15,000 to $30,000 / year
- **Capital Construction Costs:**
  - Estimated **1% to 5% increase** in total project costs.
- **Capital Diversion:**
  - Mandating continuous in-room sensors, 5-year airflow rebalancing, and rapid filter turnover diverts limited capital from primary climate initiatives:
    - Solar installs
    - Building envelope sealing
    - Fleet electrification
  - *Increasing ventilation rates above codes and standards could risk the longevity of our aging systems and increased failure rates of our building systems.*



3rd-Party Technical Evaluation
Industry Expert Findings & Standards Baseline

- **About Apex Companies:** 38 years of experience, ~2,000 expert consultants in ESG, environment, compliance, and health & safety.
- **Regulatory Code vs. Voluntary Guidance:**
  - **Oregon Mechanical Specialty Code (OMSC) / ASHRAE 62.1-2022:** Legally adopted, peer-reviewed engineering standards balancing air quality, energy efficiency, and cost.
  - **Harvard Healthy Buildings Program:** Voluntary pandemic mitigation research framework; not a regulatory design standard (targets are 50%–200% higher than code minimums).
- **Key Finding:** Air Change Rates (ACH) alone are not a universally accepted benchmark for ventilation safety or system efficacy.



Climate Crisis Response Committee Involvement

- **Climate Crisis Response Committee (CCRC):**
  - Charter: 9 members (2 students, 7 adults) advising the Board on CCRP implementation.
  - Current Status: **Not consulted** on the proposed policy expansion.
- **Governance Concerns:**
  - Alters committee oversight scope without committee member input.
  - Risks setting a precedent for rushed policy modifications that could compromise long-term climate targets.
- **Best Practice:** Have the IAQ policy exist independent of the CCRC, or, at minimum, engage the CCRC to ensure policy stability and alignment with original charter goals.

"The mission of the Climate Crisis Response Committee is to monitor effective implementation, provide transparency, and to track and report progress or challenges of the Portland Public Schools's Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice and Sustainable Practices Policy and the goals in it."



Staff Recommendation & Next Steps

- **Pause Policy Adoption:** Pause embedding IAQ additions into the CCRP to allow thorough Board review of 3rd-party data.
- **Maintain Policy Boundaries:** Keep CCRP focused on emissions reduction, net-zero goals, and structural climate action.
- **If Establishing a Standalone Policy:** Draft a separate, dedicated IAQ policy supported by an IAQ Coordinator and tailored operational procedures and non-conflicting goals of CCRP.
- **Review Supporting Materials:**
  - April 2026 FIOC Committee Air Quality Presentation
  - November 2026 Policy Committee Air Quality Presentation
  - November 2026 Air Quality Policy Staff Memo
  - Third-Party Evaluation Report (Apex) for Atkinson Elementary



Thank You



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